Sotheby

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Dining Etiquette

TLE-01

The Lady's Etiquette

Dining Etiquette

The Lady's Code of Conduct: Revised Edition
Chapter 1: Dining Etiquette

1. When attending formal dining occasions, one must wear a hat and gloves.

The Hall in the Suitcase

Eagle: Do I really need to wear a hat to Ms. Sotheby's dinner party? I've never been to such a high-class event before.

Eagle: Hmm, no, think again, think again.

The desire to meet the standards of others is one that even a child isn't spared from.

The nervous little girl takes off her Scout cap, reluctantly putting it back in the closet.

Eagle: Maybe I should change into something else? Mr. APPLe's Complete Guide to Education and Social Etiquette says that it's important to follow the dress code of a formal dinner.

Eagle: That's right. You have to be meticulous in how you present yourself to avoid leaving a bad impression.

She rummages through her things and pulls out a crumpled little dress, a birthday gift from her father when she was eleven.

Even during the height of the war, her father planned out every gift his daughter would receive at each age.

She wipes the sweat off her palms onto her skirt as she looks at herself in the mirror.

Eagle: That's strange. There should be a pussy bow here. A cute, soft one, perfect for a dinner party.

Eagle: What if I pick two leaves from outside and fashion them into a bow?

Eagle: No. I mustn't think like that. A Scout would never damage public property.

The alarm cuts through her deliberations, reminding her of how little time she has left to decide.

Eagle: Uh-oh, time's up.

She stops the alarm and dashes out the door.

2. When attending important events, one must never be late or early.

Eagle: Ms. Sotheby? Where's Ms. Sotheby's room?

Ms. Moissan: Oh—goodness! Slow down, child!

Ms. Moissan: Ah, Ms. Eagle?

Ms. Moissan: Come on now, dear. The more anxious you are, the more you ought to relax. Take a deep breath, and slow down.

Eagle: *huff, huff, huff*

Ms. Moissan smiles as she watches Eagle regulate her breathing, her little flushed face gradually returning to its normal color.

Eagle: Sorry, Ms. Moissan, I didn't mean to be rushing around.

Eagle: It's just that Ms. Sotheby invited me to her dinner party, and I have to be on time.

Ms. Moissan checks her watch.

Ms. Moissan: A dinner party? Hmm, then you might well be late already.

Ms. Moissan: Generally, a formal dinner party starts at eight o'clock sharp. It's now 8:01. You'd be—

Before she can finish her sentence, Eagle has already dashed off down the hallway.

3. Cutlery must be arranged according to specific standards at any formal dinner party. Knives and spoons are placed on the right, while forks must be placed on the left.

Sotheby's Room

Sotheby: La-la-di-da! Teaspoon, egg spoon, melon spoon, grapefruit spoon ...

This room is always lively, hosting parties and dinners for all kinds of friends.

The hostess of the room is wearing a fancy green satin hat, and her jewelry shows the signature sparkle of the Corona Borealis brand.

Her heels clack as she makes her way around the table to arrange the cutlery.

Footsteps echo from the hallway, growing louder as they approach.

Eagle: Reporting! I'm so sorry!

Eagle: It's my first time attending such a fancy dinner party, and I'm afraid of making mistakes. I-I studied every page of the Complete Guide to Education and Social Etiquette, but the rules are still too complicated for me.

Eagle: Wait, no, a good Scout shouldn't make excuses for their mistakes. I've broken the etiquette rules, so go ahead and punish me! I'll do a hundred push-ups, no, a thousand!

Twins Sleep: Come sit! Come sit!

The twins, Lisa and Louise, sit at the table, eagerly waiting for the dinner to start.

The hostess of the room spins around and stops in front of Eagle. The little Scout's ears turn red with embarrassment.

Sotheby: Oh! You're here! How wonderful it is to see you, my dear friend!

She gives Eagle a welcoming smile.

4. One must stand behind one's chair and wait for the host or hostess to sit first. When entering and leaving one's seat, one must enter from the left and exit from the right.

Eagle stands behind her chair, nervously waiting for the hostess to sit down.

Sotheby: Huh? What's that grumbling sound? It can't be a Carbuncle licking its fur, so it must be someone's stomach growling!

The anticipation seems to reach its peak, as everyone is waiting for the dinner to begin.

Eagle swallows, wondering what delicious food they'll be feasting on.

Sotheby turns around, takes her seat, and looks around the room, nodding in satisfaction.

Sotheby: Alright! Let's get started, shall we?

A strange-looking little black doll stumbles out of the kitchen, carrying far more food in its arms than it can possibly handle.

Sotheby: This is our appetizer! Nachos covered in delicious powdered cheese!

The doll jumps onto the table, scattering nachos everywhere as it frantically pours the chips into Lisa's and Louise's bowls.

Sotheby: Whoa—yummy! Go ahead and dip them in the Sticky Snot Syrup! It's delicious!

Having distributed the food, the little black doll slyly grabs a nacho and quietly puts it in its mouth.

The little Scout's eyes widen.

Eagle: Ahem, and these are ...?

But she quickly falls silent. Apparently, commenting on the dishes is also against etiquette.

Sotheby: Next up, we have our Mini Mischief Mint Chocolates and Pop-a-Rock Rainbow Candy!

Sotheby: Give them a try! They come in all sorts of different flavors! Some taste like dragonflies and morning dew, and others make you croak like a frog! Hehe!

The hostess continues, overwhelmed by her excitement.

Sotheby: Oh, and there's more! Does anyone else miss the little bear cookies from the Nabiscuit Company?

Sotheby: Well, I have them! Aren't they cute? This one looks like a snowman! And this one over here—it looks like a Buru Lizard, don't you think?

No one dares touch the cutlery. Even the twins exchange puzzled glances.

Sotheby: Oh, oh! And the highly anticipated main course—Popping Candy Popcorn!

Sotheby: A unique creation by Sotheby herself! They puff up like little clouds and burst like magical carbonated bubbles! They'll make you want to bounce up and down, and you'll see a rainbow!

Sotheby: Oh, and paired with these cupcakes, they'll make for a sensational taste experience!

Her introduction is over.

Sotheby kisses the little black doll she has infused with her arcane skill.

Sotheby: Thank you, Typhon!

The doll deflates like a balloon. Before long, it's lying limp on her lap. Sotheby hangs it back on her pocket watch.

Eagle: E-Excuse me ...

Eagle: Is this what we're going to eat now?

Sotheby: Of course, why else would I host a formal dinner party?

Eagle: But, Ms. Sotheby, haven't you ...

Eagle: Haven't you noticed these are all snacks?

Sotheby: Yes! They're snacks—the greatest snacks ever!

Eagle: So, we're eating snacks for dinner?

Eagle: The officers in the barracks call this "energy-draining junk food."

Sotheby: Junk food? Hmm, if by that you mean "amazingly delicious," then yes! It's "junk food"!

She blinks, her natural optimism glowing in her large green eyes, and forks a cookie into her mouth.

Meanwhile, the serious little Scout holds her knife and fork, staring at the assortment of candy, chocolates, and nachos on her plate, unsure of how to proceed.

Sotheby: Huh? What's wrong? Why aren't you eating?

Twins Sleep: Yes, why aren't you? It's so hard to find snacks like these in the suitcase.

Eagle: I-I don't want to eat snacks. A Scout should focus on nutrition, not candy and chocolate.

Sotheby: Oh, really? But I've heard what you talk about in your sleep.

Indeed, Eagle's father once left her a bag of Pop-a-Rock Rainbow Candy, and she indulged in every single one.

Eagle: Oh ... th-that's ...

The guilty little Scout is speechless.

Sotheby: Yes! So I made these for everyone! It wasn't hard; I can mimic the Nabiscuit Company's products to a T!

Eagle looks up in shock at the enthusiastic hostess.

Eagle: You mean, you made all these snacks yourself?

Sotheby: Yes! Lady Sotheby made them all herself.

In the midst of their conversation, no one has noticed that the Popping Candy Popcorn has been slowly expanding all this time.

Hot steam has started to rise from it.

But Sotheby is too lost in the excitement of the conversation.

Sotheby: Popping Candy Popcorn is my latest creation, you know. I worked ever so hard on it. It took thirty-eight failed experiments to finally land on the perfect one.

Sotheby: But this number thirty-nine is the perfect formula. It has—

bang

The dish at the center of the table explodes, filling the room with smoke.

Sotheby: What? What's happening?

Twins Sleep: It exploded! It exploded!

Sotheby: *cough*

Sotheby: An explosion? From where?

Eagle: The main course—the Popping Candy Popcorn—it exploded!

Sotheby: Impossible! Popping Candy Popcorn is the result of long experimentation! It couldn't possibly just ...

Sotheby: *cough*

She quickly pulls the explosive snack from the depths of the smoke and throws it out the window, still in disbelief at what has happened.

boom A blaze ignites in the Wilderness outside.

Eagle: Will Ms. Vertin get mad at us for damaging public property?

A sorrow envelopes the room, with some worrying about being scolded by their "landlord" and others realizing their thirty-ninth experiment has ended in failure.

Sotheby: Why did this happen? The calcium carbonate mixture and bubble essence didn't work together? But I already increased the dosage.

As the thick smoke clears, it reveals the large hole that has been blasted in the wall of Sotheby's room.

On the other side is Sotheby's neighbor, sitting on the edge of her bed.

She is extremely thin and pale and wearing a nightgown.

She has a medical drip by her side and bandages on her arms and legs.

She leans over to look at the scene of the incident.

Cristallo: Um, sorry to interrupt you, but ...

Cristallo: Popcorn is made from corn.

Sotheby: What did you say?

The earlier explosion has caused a brief ringing in Sotheby's ears.

Cristallo: It's like this ...

The pale girl tries to raise her voice, but the sound that comes from her throat is still faint.

Cristallo: Popcorn—is—made—from—corn!

Her gentle, nasal voice lingers in the air before dissipating with the smoke.

Lisa and Louise look at Cristallo, soot all over their faces.

Sotheby: Wow.

Sotheby is stunned by this statement.

Sotheby: That's the most interesting thing I've heard for a while.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Social Etiquette

TLE-02

Social Etiquette

Popping Candy Popcorn—

Once you put it in your mouth, it will dance, fight, drum, or do anything else it wants on your tongue!

After all, there were all kinds of little accidents before its final recipe was found. So, who knows what might happen?

The Hall in the Suitcase

This failure is a great setback—at least for Sotheby.

Vertin: Madam Z has approved our application for repair and subsidy funds.

Vertin: Also, since we've performed well in previous tasks, and solved a number of problems, the Foundation has approved some additional compensation.

Vertin: I'm thinking we could use these funds to buy daily snacks. How about that?

Twins Sleep: Yay! Finally, some real snacks to eat!

APPLe: This APPLe quite enjoys tasting snacks from various times; it is said that different snacks can have a variety of effects on our emotions.

It seems that everyone is delighted with the Timekeeper's idea of providing plenty of snacks. All except for one.

Eagle: Um, Ms. Sotheby? You look distracted. What are you thinking about?

Sotheby: Hm? Oh! I ... What was I thinking about?

Vertin: Sotheby, could you come with me for a moment?

Cristallo's Room

Vertin: I don't mind about the damage to the suitcase. It won't take long to fix.

Vertin: But I do wish you would talk to Ms. Cristallo.

Vertin: She's still undergoing treatment and really needs a quiet environment to recuperate. Having explosions go off in the room next door isn't really appropriate, is it?

Sotheby: N-No, it isn't. I'm sorry!

She drops her head, the large feather in her hat quivering as she holds back her emotions.

Sotheby: I never thought my dinner party would have such a negative impact! This ... this is not very becoming of a lady!

Cristallo, who is sitting on the bed nearby, slowly closes her book.

Cristallo: Actually ...

Cristallo: I felt great when I woke up this morning.

Cristallo: I think the explosion yesterday may have given me an adrenaline rush—I feel much more energized.

Vertin: Hmm ...

Vertin: Interesting. I certainly didn't expect that.

Cristallo: Look, this is my physical examination report from this morning. Everything's almost up to standard.

A knock at the door interrupts them.

Sonetto: Timekeeper, it's time to go. Madam Z has been waiting for a while.

Vertin: Just a moment, Sonetto.

The two girls before her lean against each other, looking up innocently.

Vertin: Alright, maybe it's best if I'm not here. I hope you two can become friends.

Sotheby: Don't worry. We will!

Sotheby returns to her cheerful self. She enjoys taking on tasks.

Vertin nods, satisfied with their answer.

She leaves, closing the door behind her with a soft click.

A somewhat restrained silence permeates the room.

The two girls exchange looks, kindness and curiosity on their faces.

The pale girl breaks the ice.

Cristallo: Snacks, right?

Sotheby: No!

Her voice carries both gratitude for the choice of topic and excitement at having had the ice broken.

Cristallo: So, you know that popcorn comes from a tall plant called wild Mexican corn, right?

Sotheby's eyes widen with excitement.

Cristallo: I think it was around seven thousand years ago that these plants were cultivated by the Native Americans.

Cristallo: Each corn kernel is encased in a hard shell, and as it heats up, the core expands.

Cristallo: When the temperature reaches a certain point, the internal pressure exceeds the shell's resistance, causing it to pop.

Cristallo: When the hot starch and water vapor meet the cold air outside the shell, it cools quickly and forms a cloud-like shape.

Sotheby: Wow!

Cristallo: So ...

Cristallo: If it's not too much trouble, could I have the honor of tasting your Popping Candy Popcorn?

Sotheby looks at her for a long time.

Sotheby: W-W-Well, of course!

The Lady's Code of Conduct: Revised Edition
Chapter 2: Social Etiquette

1. Never lose composure while in company; one must always maintain a ladylike appearance.

Sotheby's Room

Sotheby: Careful, careful, careful! The latest batch of experimental Popping Candy Popcorn is here!

Sotheby: This time, I've added more cinnamon and toad powder, and a little less belladonna!

Sotheby: Aren't the colors pretty? I'm certain that eating this will make you dance with joy!

Cristallo: Alright, experiment number forty-eight ...

Cristallo: If it tastes good, I'll draw a smiley face on this sticky note.

Sotheby: Great! Have any products gotten a smiley face yet?

Cristallo: Uh, we'll have some soon.

Cristallo tosses two green popcorn pieces into her mouth.

Cristallo: This batch tastes pretty good—but not as good as batch forty-seven. What do you think?

Sotheby: Forty-seven? Um, which one was that again?

Cristallo: The batch that grew blue fur, I think.

Sotheby: Oh, those ones. They did look odd, but they certainly tasted the best!

Sotheby: Let's go back to that recipe as a starting point and adjust from there.

Sotheby: I think we still have some left. Oh! They're right here!

Sotheby scoops a spoonful of blue popcorn and puts it into her mouth.

Sotheby: Oh, goodness! Is this a side effect of the sweetness?

The churning feeling in her stomach is unbearable.

Cristallo watches Sotheby, wishing she could get out of bed to help her poor friend.

And Sotheby, writhing on the floor from the abdominal pain, looks up at the ceiling.

Sotheby: Huh? Hey, hey, what's happening? Why is everything spinning?

Cristallo: Oh no, you ate too much, Ms. Sotheby. Do you remember what you added to that batch?

Sotheby: Belladonna? Yes, lots of belladonna. Hehehe!

Sotheby: Oh, goodness, am I on the Auto Island? Am I whizzing head first into the great legend of Typhon and his mythical kingdom?

Cristallo looks at her friend and then at the blue popcorn on the table.

Cristallo: Typhon's kingdom? Wait for me!

She pulls herself out of bed, gently picks up a few pieces of popcorn, and puts them in her mouth.

Cristallo: Ah, ah, Typhon?

Cristallo: Hah ... woah! So dizzy, haha ...

She wobbles around in a circle before collapsing to the ground.

She's always found it difficult to let go. But at this moment, she dares to try.

Cristallo: Ah—wait, oh!

Cristallo: Oh, yes! I see it too! It's Typhon! The little black doll.

Cristallo: Hahaha—it's spinning, Ms. Sotheby, it's spinning! How fun!

Sotheby: Yes! Ms. Cristallo! Spinning, so much spinning! Hahaha!

...

From dawn to dusk, the ecosystem in the suitcase changes multiple times.

The nightlight shines into the room, illuminating the table filled with potions and popcorn samples, the floor piled with experimental instruments, medical supplies, and colorful trash, and the two girls lying among them.

To the girls, the ceiling seems like a night sky dotted with stars, and the air smells pleasantly sweet.

Their hallucinations make the ordinary intriguing.

Sotheby: Honestly, Ms. Cristallo, you're the most knowledgeable person I've ever met. I officially declare you my most admired person—after Typhon, of course!

Cristallo: I'm not all that special. I just have a lot of time to read, given how much time I spend in bed.

Sincerity flows like water between them.

Cristallo: Actually, if you don't mind, I want to tell you something.

Sotheby: Of course, I don't mind!

Cristallo: Really?

Sotheby: Of course! You're my good friend! I wouldn't mind a thing from a good friend!

Cristallo: Well, actually, before I started helping you with your experiments, I'd never tasted a snack before.

Sotheby: Really?!

Cristallo: Yes. The nurses always told me that snacks are "bad for my health."

Sotheby: You never even tried one?

Cristallo: Not even one.

Sotheby: Wow!

Cristallo: I, I want to try them. All of them. The new cinnamon candies, cheese sauce, pizza rolls, and those gummy rings you can wear on your fingers ...

Cristallo: Sorry, am I talking too much? I suppose they're all ordinary to you, right?

Sotheby: Wow.

She pauses.

Sotheby: Actually, I'm the same as you.

Cristallo: ...?!

Sotheby: Although I've seen some of them, I've never eaten those snacks either!

Sotheby: Mrs. April, the cook, would follow strict recipes, and Mr. Karson recorded everything I ate.

Sotheby: They were ever so serious, so I never ate anything they didn't want me to.

Cristallo: So—you haven't had any of those snacks either?

Sotheby: No!

Cristallo: Not even once?

Sotheby: No!

Cristallo rolls over.

Cristallo: So, when the kids outside say, "Today we're going to buy butternut candy, or, or cinnamon candy," what do you do? How do you respond?

Sotheby: Respond? What are you talking about? No one's ever said that to me.

Cristallo: ...?

Cristallo: Those kids outside never said that to you?

Sotheby: Kids outside?

Cristallo: Yes, outside the hospital room window—or outside the room?

Cristallo: The kids outside. You know, the kids who laughed and played outside the window every day when you were younger.

Sotheby blinks.

Sotheby: You mean those goons from Jupiter's army?

A meteor streaks across the sky, and dandelion seeds gather their strength to fly. A secret is stirring in the air.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Behavioral Etiquette

TLE-03

Behavioral Etiquette

Sotheby: Sotheby's Diary.

Sotheby: April 14th, 🌼.

Sotheby: Tomorrow is my seventh birthday.

Sotheby: I love birthdays.

Sotheby: On birthdays, there are big cakes and lots of people, and we can all play together!

Sotheby: Mr. Karson promised me that when I turn seven, I can go out to play!

Sotheby: Wow! Can you imagine it? Going out!

Sotheby: Not the door to my room, but the big door to the house!

Sotheby: I can't wait! I want to go out now!

Sotheby: Anyway, just one more day until I turn seven! I can't wait!

Sotheby: Sotheby's Diary.

Sotheby: April 16th, 🌫️.

Sotheby: Can you believe it? I actually slept through it!

Sotheby: My birthday, I slept through it! I slept through the whole day!

Sotheby: What happened? I don't remember a thing.

Sotheby: Mr. Karson won't tell me, so I'll just have to guess.

Sotheby: I remember having a dream.

Sotheby: In the dream, there were four-legged beasts screaming. Their feet were covered in mud, and my hands and bottom were covered in mud, too.

Sotheby: And I remember laughter.

Sotheby: Whose laughter is it?

Sotheby: Oh, children! Children my age!

Sotheby: But why are they laughing?

Sotheby: Are they laughing at me?

Sotheby: ...

Sotheby: Why are they laughing at me?

Sotheby: Ah, I understand! They're the young Succaraths! The little ones!

Sotheby: I get it! They must be here, looking for Typhon.

Sotheby: Typhon wants to defeat the evil Jupiter, and the little Succaraths are Jupiter's henchmen, here to help him fight!

Sotheby: Haha, the outside world is indeed dangerous! But it's so interesting!

Sotheby: Oh, but Mr. Karson told me that my parents won't let me go out alone anymore.

Cristallo: So—you don't really have many friends, do you?

The Hall in the Suitcase

Eagle: Mission accomplished. Everything appears to be stable in the suitcase. Everyone is either entertaining themselves or resting.

Before she can finish speaking, a huge explosion erupts from Sotheby's room.

Eagle: Except for one unit.

Thick smoke billows out of the room. The twins come running out of it, laughing.

Eagle: Hey, Lisa, uh, and Louise, do you know what Ms. Sotheby is up to? Sorry, today's my turn to patrol the suitcase.

Twins Sleep: Patrol the suitcase? Lisa's never heard of that, and Louise has never heard of that, either.

Eagle: *cough* It's just a ... personal mission.

Eagle: The important thing is, is Ms. Sotheby's room safe now? Is there any damage?

Twins Sleep: Ms. Sotheby and Ms. Cristallo are inventing new popcorn! Popcorn!

Eagle: Are they together?

Twins Sleep: Yes! They're together. Good friends should play together.

Eagle: Right.

Eagle: Good friends should play together—there's nothing wrong with that.

The little Scout frowns.

Eagle: But Ms. Cristallo is so fragile, and Ms. Sotheby is the most mischievous child in the camp.

She shakes her head in an attempt to dismiss her worries.

Eagle: I shouldn't think like that! Yes, always look on the bright side. They seem so happy together.

Twins Sleep: Happiness is always a good thing! Happiness is always a good thing!

A distant call cuts through their conversation.

Sotheby: Excuse me! Pardon me! The fiftieth experimental product is ready!

The sound of stumbling feet comes from within the smoke.

Sotheby: I guarantee it, this is the perfect formula!

The green whirlwind of a girl breaks through the smoke, appearing before her friends.

Eagle: Ms. Sotheby, are you still working on that popcorn thing?

Sotheby: Popping Candy Popcorn? Yes! Would you like to try some? I'm sure you'll enjoy it!

Sotheby: Oh! Feel the love! Yes, feel the love! At least Ms. Cristallo would describe it that way.

Eagle takes one from Sotheby.

Twins Sleep: It tastes really good! It has a strong corn flavor!

Eagle: Mmm, it does taste good. But, where are you getting all the corn? There certainly aren't any cornfields in the suitcase.

Sotheby: Oh! Corn? I don't use any corn.

Sotheby: That's the magic of it! It has a strong corn flavor without using corn at all! And it can make people dance, sing, and dream! La-la-la-la!

Lisa and Louise exchange puzzled looks.

Eagle: You mean, you're making popcorn without corn?

Sotheby: Yes! I add corn essence, cinnamon powder, orange peel, toad powder, belladonna—

Eagle: Wait, belladonna? Toad powder?

Sotheby: Yes! Belladonna makes people happy, and toad powder makes them spit colorful bubbles!

Eagle: Aren't they poisonous?

Worry starts to overtake her.

Sotheby: Poisonous? What are you talking about?

Sotheby: I've tested it a hundred times, and I'm totally fine! It couldn't possibly be poisonous.

Sensing that something is off, Sotheby tosses a piece of popcorn into her mouth. She gives a light burp, filling the air with a sweet scent.

Sotheby: Hmm. It tastes good, but it doesn't quite make me want to jump up and down.

Eagle looks at the popcorn in her hand, then at Sotheby. She takes a deep breath.

Eagle: Ahem, Ms. Sotheby.

Sotheby: Yes?

The Lady's Code of Conduct: Revised Edition
Chapter 3: Manners and Etiquette

Eagle: I ... I ...

Eagle: Although I like you very much, and you've helped us all a lot, I still have something I have to tell you.

Eagle: I hope you'll consider keeping some distance from Ms. Cristallo. What you're doing could be harmful to her health.

The air suddenly feels thick.

Sotheby: Wh-What are you talking about?!

Eagle: What I mean to say is—ahem—that your relationship might not be good for Cristallo as a patient.

Sotheby has never been confronted with such doubt.

Sotheby: But, I assure you, the refined and processed essence I use couldn't even harm a day-old Tatzelwurm!

1. Always show calm and kindness towards others.

Eagle: There's no way to be sure.

Eagle: All I know is that the Timekeeper warned us that her health is very fragile and that we shouldn't interfere with her treatment.

Sotheby gives Eagle a wide-eyed stare.

Sotheby: Ms. Eagle. Don't you trust me?

Eagle: Uh!

Eagle scratches her face, shifting her gaze away from Sotheby.

Twins Sleep: Hmph! Lisa doesn't like this. Louise doesn't like this.

The twins pout, tugging at each other's sleeves.

The two girls stand face to face, neither willing to give in to the other.

Ms. Moissan: Did I hear mention of the Timekeeper?

Twins Sleep: Ms. Moissan!

Thank goodness, an adult has arrived.

Ms. Moissan walks over and smiles.

Ms. Moissan: Forgive me for eavesdropping. It sounds like you're having a disagreement, am I right?

Ms. Moissan questions the girls to ensure she fully understands the situation.

After hearing their explanation, she sighs.

Ms. Moissan: Perhaps—Sotheby, perhaps they're right.

Sotheby: Huh?

She looks up at Ms. Moissan in confusion.

Facing this "judgment," she sniffs, trying to pull tears from her eyes to gain the adult's sympathy.

But adults will always try to reason.

Ms. Moissan: I know it's difficult for you to accept right now, but maybe Ms. Cristallo doesn't like being disturbed?

Ms. Moissan: Allowing her more time to rest and interrupting her less often is what's best for her right now.

Sotheby: ...

Ms. Moissan: How about it? Sotheby?

Sotheby's fingers tightly twist up in her skirt. She lowers her head as she tries to control her breathing.

Everyone watches on in silence.

Eagle frowns, still reflecting on their conversation.

Finally, Sotheby moves.

Sotheby: But you don't understand how amazing she is or what she means to me.

Sotheby: She taught me the difference between steak and a cow—even though I always thought they were essentially the same thing.

Sotheby: She also taught me what a baby Dingonek is called. It's a frog ... Frog? Fraw?—Frog!

Sotheby: She's the most knowledgeable person I've ever met! She's incredible—not a unicorn that has to be protected or some lazy blobfish that lies around all day!

Eagle exchanges a look with Lisa and Louise, thinks for a moment, then gently speaks.

Eagle: But steak is just meat from a cow, and frogs are always called frogs. That's just common knowledge, isn't it?

Sotheby: Common?

A hint of confusion flashes across her face.

Eagle: Yeah, they're things we know from birth, right?

Ms. Moissan: Oh, dear!

Sotheby: Know from birth?

Eagle: Yes.

There's an awkward pause.

Sotheby stands stunned.

Eagle: Alright, well, what if we think about it the other way around? What do you mean to her?

Sotheby: Me? I ...

She ponders for a moment.

Sotheby: I-I tell her stories about Typhon. Anyone who hears Typhon's stories is quickly filled with courage!

Eagle: Typhon?

Eagle mutters the name to herself.

A wind blows, ushering in silence once again.

2. In social interactions, one must be mindful, moderate, and behave in a decent manner.

Eagle: And what is Typhon exactly?

...

3. One must have a stable temper and never vent anger on others.

Sotheby's Room

Cristallo: Oh, you're later than usual. Were you having trouble mixing the materials this time?

Sotheby: Huh? Oh! Yes—yes ...

She seems a bit dazed.

Cristallo: Hey, what's wrong? What happened?

Cristallo shakes her IV stand, making a gentle clinking sound.

Sotheby: Ah! Nothing, nothing!

Sotheby: Alright, let's begin! Which batch are we on? The fifty-second! Okay. Let me see, let me see.

Cristallo: Ms. Sotheby?

Sotheby spins around the room, as if looking for something. Her skirt sweeps across the table, knocking the glassware on it.

The glass tips over, the liquid inside spilling onto the floor and making a terrible mess.

Cristallo: Ms. Sotheby!

Sotheby: Sorry! I, I—sorry.

The overhead light starts to flicker.

The two of them look up in alarm.

But it isn't just the light.

Every electrical device in the room starts to flicker—the desk lamp, the radio, the radiation therapy device ...

With the last electrical device dead, the room plunges into darkness.

Cristallo: A-A power cut?

Sotheby: Oh, goodness! Is it my eyes, or has the demon Oritau finally arrived?!

Cristallo: Don't panic, Ms. Sotheby. It's not a demon. It's just a power outage.

Sotheby: A power outage? You mean a thunderbird attack?

Cristallo: No, no, nothing that serious. It's just a circuit malfunction.

Sotheby: Are you sure? It looks just like one!

Sotheby: Oh! Sotheby knows how to deal with thunderbirds! Sotheby knows!

Cristallo: I think you must've spilled that concoction on a plug socket. It probably caused a short circuit.

Cristallo: It's not a big deal. It'll be fixed soon. Don't worry.

Sotheby: Circuit? Short circuit?

Sotheby: Wow. You really know a lot.

Cristallo: It's nothing, just common knowledge.

In the darkness, Sotheby blinks.

Sotheby: Common knowledge, you say?

Cristallo: Yes, that's right.

Sotheby: Like something you've known since birth?

Cristallo: Something like that, yes.

Cristallo gives a soft sigh.

Cristallo: I've spent my whole life surrounded by electronic medical devices, you know. I'm familiar with how they work.

Cristallo: At night, when I'm alone, I can even hear their breathing.

The liquid on the floor quickly solidifies, and as the power slowly returns, one light after another comes back on.

The brief moment of panic is over.

In the faint light, a burnt smell lingers in the air.

Cristallo: See, Ms. Sotheby, everything's fine now.

Cristallo: It's the circuit's self-protection mechanism. It automatically cuts off when there's danger.

Cristallo: Ms. Sotheby?

Sotheby: So ...

Sotheby: So, you probably don't know who Typhon is either.

The filament in the light above continues to make a noisy electric buzz.

Cristallo: ...?

Cristallo: What are you talking about?

Cristallo: Haven't we just been adventuring in Typhon's mythical kingdom together?

Cristallo: How could I forget his heroic deeds?

Sotheby: Hmm, maybe it is true.

Sotheby: Ms. Cristallo doesn't know what Typhon is, either.

Cristallo: Hey, what are you talking about? *huff*

Cristallo: *huff* What's wrong? You've been acting strange ever since you came back.

Cristallo: *huff, huff*

It isn't just Sotheby who feels something is wrong.

A familiar feeling overwhelms Cristallo. A bad feeling.

At first, it's a dull dizziness, then her breathing becomes rapid, and her vision starts to darken.

She can distinctly feel her body weakening as she begins to lose consciousness.

Cristallo: Sotheby, Sotheby ...

Sotheby: Alright, I admit it. I'm feeling a bit sad, but I don't know why.

Cristallo: Sotheby ... can you ... help me ...

Sotheby: I know, I know. I know exactly who Typhon is, but what if others don't?

Sotheby: How do I introduce him to them? How do I tell his story?

Cristallo: So, *huff*, Sotheby ...

Sotheby: What if Typhon isn't the same to others as he is to me?

Sotheby: What if, what if others see things I can't?

...

...

Sotheby: Then, how do people become friends?

Sotheby: Hm? Cristallo!!!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Communication Etiquette

TLE-04

Communication Etiquette

Private Ward

Vertin: Alright, it looks like her condition has stabilized.

Vertin: This episode might have been triggered by a scare, but the bigger issue seems to be that this radiotherapy machine suddenly lost power.

Vertin: In any case, she needs to rest for now, and we need to ensure that the radiotherapy device doesn't malfunction again.

Ms. Moissan: That's good to hear. It seems we arrived just in the nick of time.

Twins Sleep: This really scared Lisa! This really scared Louise!

Eagle: None of us had ever seen her have an episode like that before. We were really at a loss.

APPLe: Unfortunately, this APPLe cannot produce apple juice. So, what can we do to help her regain her health?

Vertin: We'll just have to wait for now.

APPLe: Hmm, perhaps Ms. Sotheby will have some good ideas? Please excuse this APPLe's excess of concern.

Sotheby: ...

APPLe: Ms. Sotheby?

Sotheby is leaning on the bed, her face so close to Cristallo's that her breath is making her hair flutter on her forehead.

Sotheby: Are you sure she'll wake up if we just wait?

Her voice sounds cautious.

Vertin: That's how it worked the last few times.

Sotheby: But she sounds like a trapped two-horned beast.

Vertin: You're right. She looks uneasy.

Sotheby: Hmm, maybe conventional medicine isn't ideal for her. I think she needs something specific to her condition.

Eagle: But we don't even know what her illness is.

Vertin: It's a congenital condition. There's no other case like it in the world.

APPLe: Not exactly cancer, but something similar to that type of illness—of course, this is just this APPLe's assessment.

Sotheby: It's the Kuchibunbun disease.

Her decisive words fall like a coin to the ground.

Vertin: ...?

Sotheby: The Kuchibunbun disease, it's obvious.

Sotheby: She needs an injection of pain-relieving dew twice a day and should take three toad egg calcium tablets. The red one will have to be cut in half and eaten in two doses.

Sotheby: Hair loss, peeling skin on fingers—they're clear signs of the Kuchibunbun disease.

Vertin: ...

Ms. Moissan: ...

APPLe: ...

After a brief, awkward silence, they decide to ignore this unheard-of term.

Eagle: Right. We really don't know what her illness is. Maybe, we just don't know her that well.

Twins Sleep: Lisa doesn't understand! Louise doesn't understand!

A hint of confusion flickers in Sotheby's eyes.

Sotheby: Huh?

A cautious yet crucial inquiry.

Eagle: No, that's not what I mean! I don't mean we don't play with her often. I mean ...

Eagle: You see, we do like each other! But ...

Twins Sleep: We're afraid of breaking the glass! Afraid of breaking the glass!

Eagle: Right. We're afraid of bumping into her or knocking her over—like, well, like now.

Twins Sleep: Danger! Danger!

Eagle: The Scout Manual says we mustn't harm our teammates, whether intentionally or unintentionally. We must protect our teammates as much as possible, including from accidents.

Vertin: Indeed. We tend to arrange fewer field missions for her.

Ms. Moissan: We've also installed a number of safety features in her room to stop her from falling or having sudden episodes.

Vertin: Yes, we've been doing our best to ensure her health and safety. After all, her body's not quite like that of an ordinary person.

Sotheby: ...

It's not a difficult concept to understand; fragile things must be well protected. People have always set such rules.

No matter how simple the logic, for a child who is persistent to the point of stubbornness, it isn't so easy to grasp.

It warrants a long and thoughtful contemplation in her own way.

Sotheby: Oh, I see. That's why she says she wants to go outside and wants to eat snacks with everyone.

Sotheby: She wants to eat those delicious butternut candies, cinnamon sweets, and the cheese sauce that makes you joyfully ticklish.

Sotheby looks at Cristallo lying on the bed.

Cristallo: So—you don't really have many friends, do you?

Sotheby: So—you don't really have many friends, do you?

The Lady's Code of Conduct: Revised Edition
Chapter 4: Conversational Etiquette

1. One must always be judicious in speech, avoid harsh or extreme words, and conceal any overly strong emotions.

Sotheby: Friends. You will have good friends.

Sotheby: Ms. Cristallo, you WILL wake up, and you WILL eat the most delicious snacks in the world, and you WILL have the most friends of anyone there ever was!

Sotheby takes a deep breath.

Sotheby: Ms. Vertin!

Vertin: ...?

Sotheby: Sotheby wishes to apply for an expedition outside the suitcase! The purpose of it is, um, to gather ingredients for the cure for the Kuchibunbun disease!

Sotheby: I know the recipe for it! I need the tongue of a wild dale cow, a hoof from an extremely dangerous four-legged beast, one not-at-all-spicy Jamaican pepper, and an ever-flying, never-dying Immortal Flower!

Sotheby: They're all easy to find! But, sadly, I don't have any of them here.

Sotheby: So, Sotheby hopes Ms. Vertin can approve her application!

Sotheby: May I please be allowed to venture outside the suitcase to find these materials? Then I can cure Ms. Cristallo!

Ms. Moissan: Outside the suitcase?

Ms. Moissan takes a deep breath.

Ms. Moissan: In the past, your materials were always procured by the manor's servants.

Ms. Moissan: They might not even exist.

Sotheby blinks.

Sotheby: Don't worry, Ms. Moissan. I'll find them.

Sotheby glances down at Typhon, who is tied around her waist.

Typhon smiles back at her.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: So be it.

Choices

1. I agree

Vertin: I agree.

Ms. Moissan: Timekeeper?!

APPLe: A sincere reminder. Timekeeper, even though we now have the Equilibrium Umbrella to deal with the "Storm," there are plenty of other dangers out there.

Vertin: True. But perhaps she isn't as oblivious to the outside world as we think.

Vertin: After all, she diagnosed Cristallo's "illness," didn't she? Something none of us could do.

APPLe: Nonsense!

APPLe: Oh, sorry. This APPLe was trying to convince himself, but unfortunately failed.

Eagle: The Kuchibunbun disease?

Vertin: Yes, the Kuchibunbun disease.

Eagle: But that's not even a recorded illness.

Vertin: Maybe not, but ...

Vertin seems reluctant to say more. She turns to Sotheby.

Vertin: Now, Sotheby.

Vertin: Go ahead. You have my permission to leave the suitcase so you can gather the materials you need.

Sotheby: Really? I can go?

Vertin: Yes.

Sotheby: Hooray!

Sotheby feels an unprecedented surge of energy.

Vertin: But for your safety, there are some things you must remember.

Vertin: I'm afraid we won't be able to assign more people to accompany you.

Vertin: So remember to keep your tracking device with you at all times.

Vertin: You have a six-hour time limit. When your six hours are over, whether you've gathered all the ingredients or not, you must return to the suitcase. At that time, Sonetto will pick you up based on the tracker's location, so don't worry about making your way back.

Vertin: Lastly, always, always carry the Equilibrium Umbrella. If there are any signs of the "Storm," contact us immediately and return to the suitcase.

Sotheby frowns as she listens, giving a serious nod from time to time. Even after Vertin finishes, she remains absorbed in the instructions, appearing somewhat dazed.

Sotheby: A brand-new solo adventure ...

Vertin: Yes, this time, it's just you.

Choices

1. So, are you ready?

Vertin: So, are you ready?

Sotheby blinks and takes a deep breath.

Sotheby: I understand.

Sotheby: Sotheby is ready!!!

2. Maintain eye contact and a sincere smile when engaged in conversation, as a smile enhances one's influence.

Sotheby: I'm going to find some real corn to make real popcorn.

Walkerland Avenue

Hawker: Step right up! Come get your Easter goods! We've got 'em all—and at a fair price!

The street is thick with activity. The crowd is bustling between sellers carting their goods. A hawker, laden with leather bags, wine jugs, and colorful plastic hairpins and jewelry, is eagerly selling his lackluster wares.

Hawker: Hey! You! N-No don't just look and leave! Did you know that the world's first edible Easter Bunny was made by the Germans in the 16th century?

Hawker: We make bunnies out of chocolate now, but the original was all sugar! Oh! And did you also know that the bunny is actually the pet of the goddess "Eostre"?! Haha!

Hawker: And the goddess's pet is made of chocolate, ain't that something? Come on up and get one, kid. Hey, come on, it's chocolate! What kind of kid doesn't love chocolate!

Sotheby: Hey, I'm not a kid. And don't touch my head.

Hawker: Oh! My apologies, my lady! You're done up so nicely. I should've known that you're no ordinary girl!

The hawker sizes up Sotheby.

Hawker: Well, an elegant and beautiful lady such as yourself surely wouldn't want to leave Walkerland Avenue empty-handed!

Hawker: How 'bout an Easter Bunny, or maybe hot cross buns and Easter eggs with a custom design?

Sotheby: Thank you for your kind introduction, but I'm looking for something. Do you know where I can find an Immortal Flower?

Hawker: What? This some kind of joke? Haha.

Sotheby: An Immortal Flower! Don't tell me you don't know it. It's Artemis's little guardian, with branches bearing thousands of grain-like fruits.

Hawker: Well, I guess you'd find something like that in the forest.

The hawker's hands begin to move subtly.

Sotheby: You're right! Then, I suppose I should look in the forest. Could you point me in the direction of the nearest one? Or the countryside! The wilds! Do you know how to get there?

A pearl earring set with a ruby falls into his palm.

Hawker: Oh! The nearest way to the countryside, let me think.

A pearl necklace slips from her neck.

Hawker: The nearest countryside area, that would be Greydog Hill. You can take a cab to the train station from here. Then it's just one stop away.

Hawker: Of course, if you prefer, you can ride in one of our carts. How does that sound, my lady? My horse'll have you there in only three hours.

Sotheby: Three hours? No, that won't do at all.

The hawker's hand reaches for Sotheby's watch.

Hawker: If you want to get there faster, we do have a motorized vehicle, but it'll cost you.

Sotheby: That's no problem!

Hawker: Hey, Leiby!

A stony-faced, hunchbacked little man wearing a flat cap comes over, looking rather unhappy.

The hawker deftly unfastens Sotheby's watch and slips it into his wine bag, then gives a signal to the one called Leiby.

Leiby understands immediately.

Leiby: So, this little lady wants to go to Greydog Hill, huh?

Sotheby: That's right!

Leiby: That ain't easy to get to. You tryin' to get there within the hour?

Sotheby: Yes.

Leiby: Hm, lemme think. This one's a tough nut. Ain't easy to find a rig in the city that can go that fast.

Leiby: I mean, Greydog Hill! That's real far off. We usually take a day to prepare for a trip out there.

As Leiby speaks, the hawker has already started picking the ornaments from Sotheby's belt.

Sotheby: Please, this is ever so important to me!

Sotheby: Immortal Flowers only grow in the grasslands. It's the only place I can get one!

Sotheby: I'll pay you lots and lots of money!

Leiby and the hawker exchange a glance.

Leiby: Alright, come on, lady. Let's take the motorcar.

Greydog Hill

Leiby: Alright, we're here.

The nearly broken-down vehicle shudders for a moment. Then, with a puff of exhaust, it stops with a clatter.

Sotheby: Wonderful! How can I possibly thank you? Here, take my jewelry! You can have it all!

Leiby: Well, alright then, heh-heh.

Leiby rubs his hands, expectation in his eyes.

Sotheby touches her ears, then her neck, wrists, and waist.

As Leiby watches her, his expression grows increasingly suspicious.

Sotheby: Huh? That's strange. Wasn't I wearing them when I left?

Leiby: You mean you ain't got no money?

Sotheby: No, no, you see, this is just a misunderstanding. It's not that I don't have money. I CAN have money. I just ...

Leiby: So I brought you all this way for nothing?

Anger is bubbling in Leiby's voice. The small man slowly gets to his feet. His shadow grows longer and longer, until it looks like a giant beech tree.

Sotheby: Wow, so, you're not ...? You're also an arcanist?

Leiby: You think you can push me around 'cause I'm small, pal? Huh?!

Leiby: You better watch yourself, little lady. Either you hand over some proper jewelry, or I'll teach you a lesson you won't forget!

Sotheby: Goodness, sir! You're being very rude indeed!

The giant shadow grows closer and closer.

Sotheby can hear her heartbeat in her chest.

Sotheby: B-Bodyguard!

Sotheby: Wow, I won? I really won! All by myself!

Sotheby: Hmph! Nobody can make Sotheby the Great Potion Alchemist surrender!

The girl revels in her victory.

Leiby: You—you ugly, stupid witch! I hope your stomach rots and maggots crawl out your eyes!

Sotheby: Ugh! How incredibly rude. He'll never be a gentleman with that kind of behavior.

Sotheby brushes the dust off her clothes and peers into the distance.

A few old houses stand in the distance. It looks like a farm.

Sotheby: That looks like a good place to ask. Maybe they know where I can find an Immortal Flower. Oh, and they have an orchard! I might find a dale cow tongue in there!

Sotheby: What a great idea! The clever Sotheby fears nothing!

Sotheby: Huh? Where did Ms. Vertin's tracker go?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Dressing Etiquette

TLE-05

Dressing Etiquette

The Hall in the Suitcase

Sonetto: Timekeeper, we lost contact with Sotheby's tracking device two hours ago.

Vertin: Where was the last infrared signal received?

Sonetto: In a small town called "Willoughby."

Sonetto: I took the liberty of looking into its history. The most notable recent report is about a racetrack shooting incident three years ago.

Sonetto: The report states that an armed assailant entered the venue and shot and killed everyone sitting in the VIP section with 7.62mm caliber bullets. Despite the high-profile nature of the crime, the assailant was never caught, and the case remains unsolved.

Vertin: The assailant wasn't caught on the spot?

Sonetto: No.

Vertin: And there were no fingerprints or traces left behind?

Sonetto: No.

Sonetto: All investigative leads inexplicably went cold.

Sonetto: The victims were all wealthy businessmen from other towns. Their families jointly sued the local police department, accusing them of shielding the perpetrator, but the court didn't rule in their favor.

Sonetto: It's a poor town with an extreme aversion to outsiders. This incident highlighted the tension between the townspeople and wealthy outsiders. No one in the town even wants to find the perpetrator. In fact, it's believed they do their best to cover for each other.

Sonetto: Because any one of them could be the killer.

Sonetto: Timekeeper, I'm worried that the situation might spiral out of our control.

Vertin: ...

Old House - Exterior, Greydog Hill

Sotheby: Hello! Is anyone home? I'd like to ask you a question!

Several pairs of eyes peek through the cracks in the various windows, doors, and drafty wooden boards. They all stare at the girl.

Sotheby: Hey, I know you're home! I know you can hear me!

The eyes remain unmoved.

Sotheby: I'm ever so sorry to disturb you, but I want to ask if any of you have seen an Immortal Flower.

Sotheby: Or a Jamaican pepper, or dale cow tongue? I really need to find them to heal my friend.

The eyes glance at each other.

Then, there is the sound of movement inside the house.

???: Where are you from?

Sotheby: Huh? Where am I from?

Sotheby: Uh, I'm from a suitcase—I mean, I'm from the great Sotheby's Manor! Yes, my name is Sotheby!

???: Sotheby?

Murmurs break out inside the house.

???: That rich guy?

???: The potion-making family?

???: Bah, you liar!

The murmuring stops. Sotheby swallows nervously.

???: ...

???: Come in, child.

The little Scout nervously twiddles her thumbs.

Eagle: Ms. Sotheby will be okay, won't she?

Vertin: ...

APPLe: Ahem, is it too late for this APPLe to raise an objection now?

Ms. Moissan: Timekeeper, should we send someone out to find her?

Eagle: Timekeeper ...

Vertin: ...

Vertin: It's not time yet.

Old House - Interior, Greydog Hill

???: So, your friend's sick, and you need to gather ingredients to help her.

Sotheby: Yes, exactly.

The old TV, showing a fuzzy "Saturday Family" broadcast, crackles in the background. The paint is peeling off the fiberboard walls.

The sound of a stew bubbling on the stove, mixed with the police sirens on the TV, creates an ominous atmosphere.

???: I see. You must be a very kind child to do all that.

???: Coffee?

A grease-stained glove offers a cup. The scorched, thick substance inside is almost unrecognizable.

Sotheby: Oh, thank you! You let me in because you know where I can find an Immortal Flower, right?

Sotheby: It's the most difficult ingredient I need for my potion. Once I find this, I can get the others in a jiffy.

Sotheby: Wow, this coffee tastes ... really strange, um ... *cough*

Sotheby: My apologies, but, may I ask what you added to it?

???: A few nutritious items. My children believe we should serve our guests the best.

Out of the shadows rolls a wheelchair carrying an elderly woman.

Sotheby: It's a little sour.

Elderly Woman: Ha, it's what we country folk drink. Of course you wouldn't be used to it!

The elderly woman spits on the floor near Sotheby's feet.

Sotheby: Oh! No, of-of course not! I ...

As if to prove something, Sotheby gulps down the rest of the coffee.

The elderly woman gives a satisfied smile.

Elderly Woman: My children will like you.

Sotheby: Thank you very much. So, now can you tell me about the Immortal Flower?

Elderly Woman: Immortal Flowers ... We know about those. My child will tell you.

Sotheby: Thank you, but where is your child? I haven't seen anyone.

Elderly Woman: Wait a moment, he'll—

Three boys of the same age run down the stairs, carrying something covered with a black cloth.

Boy I: Stinky head!

Boy II: Stinky head!

Boy III: Stinky head!

The three boys shout as they slam whatever is covered in the black cloth onto the table in front of Sotheby. They then jump onto the nearby sofa and sit cross-legged.

Sotheby: Uh ... hello ...

A sound like gnawing mice comes from under the black cloth.

Startled, Sotheby turns to look at it.

Boy I: Hey!

Something soft with a foul stench flies toward Sotheby's head.

A smelly sock from one of the boys.

The boy's now bare foot is hanging in the air as he leisurely watches Sotheby.

Sotheby: You ... I-I'm a guest! You can't just throw a sock in my face!

Boy I: Shut up, stinky head!

Sotheby's face turns bright red.

Sotheby: I'm not ... You ...

The elderly woman stands up from her seat, walks over to the three boys, and slaps each one hard across the face.

smack *smack* *smack*

Sotheby: Oh my! There's no need to do that! Please don't hit them on my account.

The elderly woman sits back down, spitting in the boys' direction.

Sotheby: Ahem. May I ask ... do any of you know where I might find an Immortal Flower?

The three boys remain silent.

Elderly Woman: What? What are you asking?

Sotheby: The Immortal Flower?

Elderly Woman: Ask my child, Little Apple.

Sotheby: Um, I am, but they're not answering me.

The elderly woman clicks her tongue, lights a pipe, and extinguishes the match with a flick. A cloud of gray smoke obscures her face.

Elderly Woman: Ah-heh-ha-ha.

Choked laughter squeezes through her nose.

She hunches over, her hands struggling to turn the wheels of her wheelchair as she maneuvers around the seats. She places her hand on the black cloth covering the container on the table.

Elderly Woman: Not those three brats—this is my child.

She pulls off the cloth to reveal a glass container. A human head with unblinking eyes is floating inside.

Eagle: I understand now.

Eagle: It must be my fault, because ...

Sonetto: Timekeeper, only one hour left.

Vertin: I know.

Sonetto: We should start preparing a rescue plan.

Vertin: ...

Sonetto: I'll begin a search based on the last known location.

Sonetto: Timekeeper, what's wrong?

Vertin: I'd like to wait a little longer.

The tension rises, but a clear voice cuts through the serious atmosphere.

Eagle: Timekeeper! I'm sorry!

Vertin: ...?

Sonetto: ...?

Eagle: It's all my fault.

Eagle: I said some bad things to Ms. Sotheby. She must have wanted to go outside because of me!

Eagle: A Scout should never leave a scoutmate in danger. I violated the rules of the Scout Manual, and I-I'm ready to accept my punishment.

Sonetto: What are you talking about?

But the little Scout seems unwilling to explain further. Her voice is trembling.

Eagle: I'm worried ...

Eagle: Ms. Sotheby ... She might already be ...

The elderly woman leans against the glass container, gazing affectionately at the head inside.

Elderly Woman: My dear child, we finally have our own little money bank.

Sotheby: Wha-What?

The elderly woman gets down from her wheelchair, limps over to a kitchen cabinet, and pulls out a rifle.

Elderly Woman: Tell those fools on Sizemore Road we've caught a rich little girl. Let's see how much we can squeeze out of her.

Sotheby: Y-You can't do this! The police will come and arrest you!

Elderly Woman: The police?

The room bursts into laughter.

Elderly Woman: We prefer the term "dogs" for those fools at Sizemore Road.

The elderly woman raises her rifle, aiming the dark barrel of the 7.62mm caliber gun directly at Sotheby.

Greydog Hill

Elderly Woman: She got away!

Her mad screams echo through the valley. Sotheby runs at full speed without so much as a glance backward.

The crazed old woman quickly reloads her rifle.

Bullets slice through the air toward Sotheby's retreating figure.

bang *bang*

The 7.62mm caliber bullets whizz through the withered grass, skimming the hem of Sotheby's dress.

It looks like it's about to rain.

The scent of soil fills her nostrils as the sticky ground makes her steps increasingly heavy.

Sotheby: *huff—huff—huff*

Her legs give way, and she slips in the mud.

Boy I: She's here!

A whistle quickly directs the footsteps of his brothers.

By the time Sotheby comes to her senses, the three boys have caught up to her, circling her like hyenas.

Sotheby: Why are you chasing me? I only wanted to ask a simple question!

One of the boys squats down, grabbing Sotheby's beautifully tied hair with one hand.

The three boys laugh together.

Boy I: She asks me why?

Boy II: She asks you why.

Boy III: We don't have a reason.

Boy I: Did you hear that?

Boy I: We don't have a reason.

Boy I: It's just for fun.

Four words.

Sotheby: It's just for fun?

Sotheby can't comprehend such an idea.

Sotheby: Sotheby's Diary.

Sotheby: April 15th.

Sotheby: I can hear that laughter again. The laughter of the little Succaraths, it's started again!

Sotheby: I asked them why they're laughing like that. I told them how very rude and uncomfortable it is!

Sotheby: And they said it's just for fun.

Sotheby: Stono Swift!

The three boys' smiles freeze.

Sotheby pulls herself off the ground. Her dress is torn. The tattered fabric drags on the ground, covered in dirt.

Sotheby: Just ... for fun ...

Sotheby: Fuego Burn!

The flame starts small but soon grows.

Flames rise from the boys' feet, illuminating their terrified faces in its amber glow.

There's a rumble of thunder. Rain is coming. The flames burn fiercely.

Sotheby: This scene, it feels like I've seen it before, just ...

Sonetto: Ten more minutes.

Sonetto: Timekeeper, I've prepared these portable floppy disks for you. They should aid you in your search.

Vertin: Hmm ...

The flames climb the grass and up the pant legs of the boys. Even the pouring rain can't stop its growth.

The rain falls, and the fire rises.

As Sotheby stands, watching, the hem of her dress also catches fire.

Sotheby: I knew it. Mr. Karson must've lied to me. How could I have slept through it all?

Sotheby: So the cries in my nightmares are from those four-legged beasts, and the "children outside the window" that Cristallo mentioned, I played with them.

Sotheby: Yes, it was on that birthday. I remember it all now.

Sotheby: Dirt, rain, and the hooves of the four-legged beast trampling me, and, and their laughter.

...

Sotheby: Turns out there are many kinds of laughter, and not all are friendly.

The flames continue to rise. They have reached her waist.

This fire is better than any fires.

Better than the fire in the Christmas Eve fireplace, the fire in the snow-covered villa, the fire at the tea dance, and the fire at the Toscanini concert.

It's real fire. One that will devour everything.

Sotheby: Hmm, it seems having a good memory isn't always a good thing.

Sotheby pulls herself out of her memories and looks at the three boys in front of her.

She sighs in relief, a smile on her face.

Sotheby: Flames Extinguish.

Sotheby: Petrification, release.

The boys flee in panic.

Their screams echo through the valley. It's unlikely they will ever bully anyone again.

The rain is still falling, soaking Sotheby's head and shoulders. Her knees are muddy, and her arms are scratched and bleeding.

She looks toward the ashen sky, where a bright ray of sunlight is struggling to break through the clouds.

Sotheby: Oh! I almost forgot! My Easter chocolate!

She pulls out the chocolate from her pocket. It's drenched.

Sotheby: Haha—Happy Easter!

She seems to remember something. She blinks and smiles.

Sotheby: Huh? Isn't today also my birthday?

Walkerland Avenue

Sonetto: Timekeeper, I've found her tracker.

Sonetto: I asked a man selling Easter eggs nearby. He said he saw a girl in a green dress heading toward Greydog Hill.

Sonetto: Let's go.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: Yes. It's time.

A disheveled-looking Sotheby bursts through the crowded market on the back of a horse, trampling various crafts in the process.

Sotheby: Oh, dear! I'm ever so sorry! I'll be sure to pay you back!

Sotheby: And you, and you as well! Ooh, this one's truly exquisite! I'll compensate you tenfold!

Sotheby: What? Are you talking about my four-legged beast? It's very well-behaved! I'll make it apologize to you too!

Sonetto: Timekeeper. Is that ...

Vertin: Yes.

Sonetto blinks.

Sonetto: Timekeeper, are you smiling?

Sotheby: Oh! Ms. Vertin! Ms. Sonetto! Have you been waiting for me?

She pulls the reins tightly. Her hat is half-missing and crooked, her sleeves are stained with blood, and her skirt is charred and tattered.

She's in rags, but her smile is joyful.

Sotheby: Whoa!

The horse comes to a steady stop in front of them, breathing heavily through its large nostrils.

Sotheby gently strokes its head.

Sotheby: Thank you, little one. Thank you for bringing me back.

She looks up and, imitating Eagle, reports loudly.

Sotheby: Ms. Vertin, my exploration outside the suitcase is complete!

Sotheby: I've gathered all the ingredients needed to treat Ms. Cristallo's condition.

Sotheby: And I've got corn seeds too!

The Lady's Code of Conduct: Revised Edition
Chapter 5: Dressing Etiquette

1. One must maintain a neat and tidy appearance and avoid dirtying or damaging clothes. In the case of an accident, change promptly.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Sixth Etiquette

TLE-06

The Sixth Etiquette

Sotheby's Dream

A cotton swab dipped in iodine is gently pressed against Sotheby's wound.

Sotheby: Ooh, ouch ...

???: Miss, please bear with me for a moment. It'll be over soon.

Sotheby: Oh! N-No, I didn't mean it! It doesn't hurt. Keep going.

Moonlight streams through the floor-length windows and into the quiet room.

The gentle sound of the piano fills the air.

???: I admit music can distract from and alleviate pain, but even the most moving melody loses its charm when played repeatedly. Miss, perhaps you should try a different piece.

Sotheby: But I like playing this one.

???: In that case, you need to learn a new piece. I assure you, you'll enjoy playing something new.

Sotheby: Ouch!

???: I do apologize, Ms. Sotheby. Does the potion sting?

Sotheby: Mr. Karson ...

Mr. Karson: Yes, my lady?

Sotheby: If this tiny wound hurts this much, what does it feel like to die?

Mr. Karson: Hmm. That's a good question, and you asked the right person.

Mr. Karson: Are you afraid of death?

Sotheby: I-I wasn't afraid before. It was just a nightmare, a darkness or long sleep.

Mr. Karson: And now?

Sotheby: Now ...

Sotheby: I'm a little scared.

Mr. Karson: Why?

Sotheby: Because it'll take my friends away.

Sotheby: Like they'll fall asleep and never wake up.

Mr. Karson: Alright, switch hands.

Sotheby extends her other hand, and Mr. Karson gently applies the cotton swab to the wound on it.

Mr. Karson: Ultimately, you're afraid of loneliness.

Sotheby: I'm not afraid of loneliness. Sotheby is not afraid of loneliness.

Mr. Karson: It's quite alright, my lady. No one wants to be lonely.

Mr. Karson: But loneliness is not a monster; it's not enough to overwhelm a person.

Mr. Karson: There are many people in this world who have done wrong in their lives, and oftentimes they don't even know why they do it.

Mr. Karson: Ultimately, it's because they're afraid of being lonely.

Mr. Karson: But the fact is, loneliness isn't that scary.

Mr. Karson: Just as all monsters have an Achilles' heel, loneliness has its remedy.

Sotheby: What is it?

Mr. Karson: I think you may already know the answer, my lady.

He puts down the cotton swab and carefully inspects Sotheby's wounds.

Mr. Karson: I'm afraid I have to go now.

Mr. Karson: I'll come and see you next time. I'm sure that by then, you'll be an even more trustworthy young lady.

Sotheby's Room

Sotheby: Hmm ... huh ... did I fall asleep ...?

A light knock raps on the door before it creaks open.

Eagle: Can I come in?

Sotheby: Hmm? Oh, it's you! Of course!

The little Scout slowly shuffles in.

Eagle: Ms. Sotheby, how's that potion coming along?

Sotheby: Oh! The potion! Yes, it's all finished. They're in these test tubes over here.

Sotheby proudly raises her head as she shows her friend her masterpiece.

Sotheby: I already gave Ms. Cristallo a little bit. Once she wakes up, she can drink some more, and it'll work even better!

Eagle stands by the door, wanting to come closer but feeling too timid to do so.

Sotheby strides over to Eagle, takes her hand, and leads her to the experimentation table. She taps the test tubes.

Sotheby: Listen. Don't they make a pretty sound?

Sotheby: "Ding ding dang dong," "boo bop du dop," such bright melodies!

Eagle tentatively reaches out a finger and, like Sotheby, gently taps the test tubes.

They sway like wind chimes, producing a series of crisp sounds.

Sotheby: Hehe, do you like it? I love doing this on a quiet night. It's so much fun!

Eagle: Yeah, I like it. It's interesting.

She smiles shyly, but behind her eyes, it's clear to see that she has something to say.

Sotheby looks at Eagle, places the test tube aside, and sits back on the bed, swinging her legs.

Sotheby: Well, Ms. Eagle, I-I still want to play with her.

Sotheby: I want to be with my friends forever and ever.

She lowers her eyes.

Eagle: No! No—I ...

She plays with her fingers anxiously, not knowing what to say.

Eagle: I, I'm actually here to apologize.

Sotheby: ...?

Eagle: After you left, I kept thinking about what I said to you before.

Eagle: I ... you see ... I ...

Eagle: I shouldn't have said those things to you—not just about hoping you wouldn't play with her, but, many, many other things, too.

Eagle: I don't even know why I said it.

Eagle: Maybe it was because I also want to be friends with you, but I don't know how.

Sotheby opens a small tin box that she pulled from the cabinet.

Sotheby: Try this.

Sotheby: When you described the Pop-a-Rock Rainbow Candy to me before, I thought, wouldn't it be nice if there was a candy that, after eating it, you could see a rainbow?

Sotheby puts one in her mouth as well, and the two of them chew together.

They chew and chew.

And chew and chew some more.

Sotheby: They're a bit tough, aren't they?

The two look at each other. Sotheby is wincing, her hand on her aching jaw.

They giggle.

Eagle: Hey, I see it. There's a rainbow!

Eagle points to the ceiling.

There's nothing there.

Sotheby: One, two, three ... seven, just like Heimdall said, seven colors!

The two of them tilt their heads back, grinning at the empty ceiling.

Eagle: Look! It's Typhon!

Eagle: He's walking on the rainbow bridge. Hey! Where's he going?

Eagle: Someone's stopping him. Who is that?

Sotheby: That's Heimdall, the great hero who guards the rainbow bridge. He's giving Typhon directions!

Eagle: Where's Typhon going?

Sotheby: He's going to battle with Jupiter and his army!

Eagle: Who's Jupiter?

Sotheby: Oh, he's a really bad man. His minions are always giving Typhon trouble. They've even come to bother me, but I managed to drive them off!

Eagle: Wow—that's amazing!

Eagle: I hereby present you, Lady Sotheby, Captain of Typhon's army and leader in the victorious battle against Jupiter's army, with this first-class medal of honor.

The little Scout wobbles as she sits up, unpins the badge from her chest, and solemnly pins it to Sotheby's dress.

Sotheby: It is my honor, Commander!

Sotheby wobbles as she sits up and gives Eagle a less-than-perfect salute.

Eagle adjusts Sotheby's hand to the correct salute position, then lies back down.

Eagle: Hehe! Hahaha!

Sotheby: Hahaha!

The two laugh together.

The night is still long.

The Lady's Code of Conduct: Revised Edition
Chapter 6 ...

The Hall in the Suitcase

Sonetto: The results of Cristallo's examination are in. A coagulation dysfunction caused temporary asphyxiation, which led to her fainting. No plant toxins have been found in her body.

Vertin: So the popcorn wasn't toxic after all.

Vertin: We shouldn't have worried so much. She meticulously measured the herbal ingredients, ensuring they would cause no harm to humans.

Vertin: If there is any effect at all, it's probably just a slight, pleasant hallucination.

Vertin: There's no denying that she's skilled in managing toxins.

Sonetto: Dale cow tongue isn't a part of a fictional creature, but an arcane herb known as "dyed pearl grass." It's used in basic potions for healing and good luck.

Sonetto: The hoof of the four-legged beast is just a horse's hoof, and Jamaican pepper is also known as "allspice."

Sonetto: Finally, an Immortal Flower is actually a naturally growing arcane plant called "thousand-spike crop." It's used in some unusual rituals.

Vertin: She has her own understanding of things, but that doesn't mean the things she mentions don't exist.

Sonetto: Although it won't cure Cristallo's condition, the potion will make her much more comfortable, and she won't faint anymore.

As they speak, a little head peeks out from the wall.

Eagle: Psst—Ms. Vertin, Ms. Sonetto, come over here.

The little Scout presses her finger to her lips.

With deliberately lowered voices, the children seem to be preparing something—either a prank or a surprise.

Sonetto: What's the matter, Eagle?

A large feathered hat also peeks out from the wall. Their two little heads are stacked one on top of the other. They both frown, their eyes bright and their expressions serious.

Sotheby: Shh! Come here—and turn the lights off.

Sotheby: Walk softly, hurry up!

It feels like she had been in the dark for an eternity.

As consciousness returns to her body, the pale girl slowly sits up, her hand on her forehead.

The emptiness of the room makes her shudder. Before she slept, she was in the middle of the chaos, but now that she's woken up, she's alone again.

Cristallo: Uh ...

Cristallo: Where am I?

Cristallo: ...

Cristallo: Oh, this is my room.

Cristallo: I'm in my room.

Cristallo: It's so quiet. Nothing like my dream.

Cristallo: *shiver* It's a bit cold. Is the window open?

Cristallo: Did someone come in?

Cristallo: Sotheby, that's right. I remember now.

Cristallo: She was talking to me, but I couldn't hear her. Then, I can't remember a thing.

Cristallo: Hah.

Cristallo: Seems like I fainted again.

She lowers her head and sighs softly.

Cristallo: It's so quiet.

Cristallo: At night, when everyone else is asleep, I'm awake.

Cristallo: And when everyone else is awake, I'm asleep.

Cristallo: Hmm, maybe I scared her. Should I apologize?

Cristallo: "Sorry, I didn't hear what you said," "Sorry for suddenly fainting" ...?

Cristallo: It's not like I haven't tried that before. Apologies don't work.

Cristallo: Everyone leaves eventually, and I'll be alone once again.

Cristallo: You scared her. She won't want to spend time with you anymore.

...

...

She sits in familiar silence.

Cristallo: Alright, now let me see if I can close this window.

Cristallo: *huff, huff* ...

She struggles to prop herself up. As she turns, looking down at her feet dangling off the end of the bed, she notices something.

A small black creature has popped its head out from under the bed.

Cristallo: Ah! What is that?!

It climbs onto the bed, an apologetic look on its face. It grabs her hand in a nervous attempt to comfort her.

Cristallo: Who are ...?

Cristallo: Are you Typhon?

The little black creature nods excitedly, points to the window, and hops over to close it.

Cristallo: Thank you, Typhon. Did Sotheby send you?

Typhon nods.

Cristallo: Where is she? Does she not want to see me?

Typhon shakes its head frantically.

It points outside the room.

Cristallo: Is she out there?

Typhon doesn't reply. It jumps down from the windowsill and hurries back to Cristallo's bedside, nearly stepping on its own tail on the way.

Taking a deep breath, Typhon begins to grow larger.

Cristallo: What are you doing? Hey!

It doesn't respond, only growing larger and larger.

Soon, it is so large that its inflated body starts to push Cristallo's bed toward the door.

Cristallo: Where are you taking me?

Cristallo: Typhon?

Cristallo: I-I've never left my room! Just give me a moment to prepare!

Cristallo: Hey! Typhon, don't scare me! Everyone's asleep! We shouldn't disturb ...

Cristallo: Don't!

The little black creature continues to manically push Cristallo's bed all the way down the hallway. She has to cling to its sides to balance herself.

The door bursts open.

There is a flash of white light, followed by a sudden, brief dizziness.

Then, above her head, comes the continuous sound of popping. They're not loud, like an explosion, but gentle and fragrant, like a flower bursting open.

pop *pop* *pop* The air is quickly filled with a sweet aroma.

Sotheby: Ms. Cristallo!

Everyone: Cristallo!

The pale girl opens her eyes.

Twins Sleep: Ms. Cristallo! Come and try some! Come and try some!

Cristallo: Th-This is ...?

Sotheby: Popping Candy Popcorn!

Sotheby: I made it with real corn this time!

Cristallo: Corn?! Did you find a cornfield?

Vertin: Sotheby got some corn seeds from outside the suitcase, so we allocated a piece of land in the Wilderness to grow them on.

Vertin: We used a growth potion to hasten the growing process.

Sotheby: You should also thank Ms. Eagle! She came up with the brilliant idea of adding pepper candy to the popcorn—it's even more delicious now!

Eagle: Pfft ... *cough* *cough* *cough*

The little Scout blushes as she offers Cristallo a handshake.

Cristallo smiles and takes her hand.

Their hands shake firmly.

Sotheby: Experiment number fifty-three is successful!

Sotheby: You can draw a smiley face on the sticky note now, Ms. Cristallo!

The popcorn is falling like flower petals.

Twins Sleep: Lisa has grabbed a lot! Louise has grabbed a lot!

Ms. Moissan: The blue ones taste like a stream.

Eagle: The pink ones are the best! They're like flowers! Wait, no—the green ones are my favorite!

APPLe: This APPLe prefers the red ones. They conjure up the image of parchment and a crackling fire, something you'd want to revisit on a winter night with the thrilling works of Christopher Marlowe.

Sonetto: Timekeeper, may I ...?

Vertin: Hmm. Try this one. You'll love it.

Sonetto: ...!

Eagle: This snack is like nothing I've ever tasted! You can definitely tell it wasn't made in any ordinary factory!

Sotheby: Really?! That's great!

Sotheby, a sparkle in her eyes, raises her head and shouts with joy.

Sotheby: Sotheby is so, so happy!

The feathers on her hat bob happily as she makes her way around the group.

Sotheby: Ms. Cristallo, you simply must try this!

She hands over a piece of golden popcorn.

Cristallo takes it and puts it in her mouth.

Cristallo: Hmm, this is popcorn.

Sotheby: Yes, this is popcorn.

Cristallo: Popping Candy Popcorn.

Sotheby: Yes, Popping Candy Popcorn.

Cristallo: It's sweet.

Sotheby: Yes.

Cristallo: It's sweet.

APPLe: Well, well, it seems our story has come to an end. But this is just one of many stories of our little lady making new friends.

APPLe: It seems that she is becoming a true lady, isn't she?

APPLe: Yes. A very, very good lady indeed.

THE END